

## States **PUNJAB**

| By Arvind Chhabra |

**S**unny day or overcast skies, most classes at the M.R. Government College in Fazilka, the historic Punjab town just 10 miles short of the Pakistan border, are held in classrooms but out in the open. It's safer as the classrooms are in a dilapidated state. Moreover, at one lecture, the group of students around the teacher isn't essentially from the same class or even studying the same subject. Astounding, but in Fazilka, it's passe since the college has only 10 teachers, including two part-timers to take care of its 2,000 students. Above all, it is the only functional government college within a radius of 100 km.

A similar story resonates in most government schools and colleges in rural Punjab, most of which are woefully short of teachers and lecturers as no one is willing to work in a remote area. Even the state Government's requisition to the Punjab Public Service Commission to appoint 265 lecturers has been pending for almost two years now. Of a total of 1,573 sanctioned posts of school principals across the state, 1,175 have been lying vacant for nearly a decade. About 30,000 vacancies of teachers in schools remain, well, vacancies. Over 65 per cent of the state's schools do not even have basic infrastructure like tables and chairs.

Cut to the state capital, Chandigarh, and you immediately know where the problem is. The notice put up prominently at the office of the directorate general, school education, saying no transfer requests are being entertained is no dampener. The place is bustling with transfer seekers as it is to the urban areas that teachers and lecturers want to be posted. Besides, many of these lecturers who came on deputation are on the verge of retirement and going by the current record, will retire as deputationists who never served their parent state. Take the case of Harvinder Kaur who was appointed by the Punjab



# Schools of SCANDAL

The reluctance of teachers to work in rural areas may well spell doom for Punjab's schools and colleges

Government as a physics lecturer in 1983 to teach at a government college but has since then been on deputation to Chandigarh's Government College for Girls. The scene in the schools is equally bad. There are around 273 deputationists, most of whom should have been teaching in one of the 23,000 Punjab schools.

These startling revelations are a result of the persistent efforts of Chandigarh's R.K. Garg. He had filed an RTI application seeking information on the deputationists from Punjab and

Haryana in Chandigarh-based schools and colleges. "My grudge is not against any particular person. But I am shocked by the way the system works. The whole system needs a revamp," he says. Needless to say, those who manage postings to Chandigarh have political clout, leaving other transfer-seekers frustrated. "We try our best to maintain a balance but it's very difficult. Perhaps we should devise a system where we have teachers work where they join. Only then can you have teachers serving in rural and remote